

Borgund Church

Location Sogne Fjord, Norway

The exterior of the late 12th-century Borgund Church is an example of how the requirements of Christian worship were fused with existing Scandinavian building types to produce a unique architecture. Constructed almost entirely of wood, Borgund Church's most obvious features are the heaped-up, weathered shingle roofs (arranged over six levels) that culminate in a tapering spire. Also noteworthy are the elaborately carved dragons' heads that project from the upper levels. The dim and sparse two-story interior follows a conventional design: the nave, marked by

12 sturdy piers, is derived from Byzantine Greek cross models. Beyond it, a substantial square chancel gives on to an apse. An internal ambulatory surrounds the entire building.

Cloth Hall

Location Ypres, Belgium

The burgeoning prosperity of the Low Countries in the high Middle Ages (c.1000–1350) gave rise to a sense

of civic pride that was expressed in a series of imposing public buildings. As “temples to trade,” they were consciously intended to rival even the largest and most opulent cathedrals. The largest of all was the 13th-century

Cloth Hall in Ypres. The principal facade, of three stories, is 433 ft (132 m) long. At its center, there is a vast square bell tower, turreted at its corners and topped by a lantern. Each end of the facade is marked by smaller but imposing spires. The entire structure, apart

from the steeply pitched roof, is smothered in a wealth of decorative detail.

Siena Cathedral

Location Siena, Italy

Siena Cathedral, built after 1226, underlines how the absolutes of French Gothic architecture were rarely echoed in medieval Italy. Superficially, there are similarities with the Gothic style; these are most obvious on the main facade, articulated by three commanding portals and a series of sculptured figures, and the large central rose window above. However, the differences are striking. For example, the hexagonal crossing is covered by a distinctly non-Gothic dome, which is topped by an

▼ SHINGLE ROOFS OF
BORGUND CHURCH

